

Day 6 — The Six Tastes & The Doṣas

Module: Doṣas · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

By the end of this lesson, students name the *ṣaḍ-rasa* (six tastes) in IAST with English meaning, identify which tastes calm and which aggravate each *doṣa*, and articulate why food is a primary lever in Ayurvedic balance.

Materials

- Six small samples (covered before the lesson starts):
 - Sweet (*madhura*) — jaggery / a piece of date
 - Sour (*amla*) — lemon wedge / amla powder
 - Salty (*lavaṇa*) — rock salt
 - Pungent (*kaṭu*) — fresh ginger / a peppercorn
 - Bitter (*tikta*) — methi leaf / a tiny bit of neem powder
 - Astringent (*kaṣāya*) — unripe banana / strong black tea
- 6 paper plates / labelled cups
- Toothpicks for sampling
- A glass of water per student for rinsing
- Allergy/dietary check completed in advance

Vocabulary introduced today

- *ṣaḍ-rasa* (IAST: *ṣaḍ-rasa*; lit. “six tastes”) — the Ayurvedic taste classification.
- *madhura*, *amla*, *lavaṇa*, *kaṭu*, *tikta*, *kaṣāya* (sweet, sour, salty, pungent, bitter, astringent) — the six tastes.

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- “How many tastes are there?” Take answers. Most students will say 5 (sweet, sour, salty, bitter, umami). Some will say 4.
- “Ayurveda counts six. The extras — pungent and astringent — are textural-chemical, not strictly the same as the modern taste-receptor 5.”

Core (15 min)

1. The six tastes — build the table on the board:

Sanskrit	English	Example	Elements that dominate	Increases	Calms
<i>madhura</i>	sweet	sugar, ghee,	earth + water	<i>kapha</i>	<i>vāta</i> , <i>pitta</i>

Sanskrit	English	Example	Elements that dominate	Increases	Calms
		rice, milk			
<i>amla</i>	sour	lemon, yoghurt, vinegar	earth + fire	<i>pitta, kapha</i>	<i>vāta</i>
<i>lavaṇa</i>	salty	rock salt, sea salt	water + fire	<i>pitta, kapha</i>	<i>vāta</i>
<i>kaṭu</i>	pungent	chili, ginger, pepper, garlic	fire + air	<i>pitta, vāta</i>	<i>kapha</i>
<i>tikta</i>	bitter	neem, turmeric, methi, dark chocolate	air + space	<i>vāta</i>	<i>pitta, kapha</i>
<i>kaṣāya</i>	astringent	unripe banana, pomegranate, black tea	air + earth	<i>vāta</i>	<i>pitta, kapha</i>

“Notice the pattern. Each taste calms exactly two doṣas and aggravates one or two.”

2. **The rule of thumb** (state simply):

- *Vāta* is calmed by **sweet, sour, salty** — warm, oily, grounding foods. Aggravated by bitter, astringent, pungent.
- *Pitta* is calmed by **sweet, bitter, astringent** — cool, mild foods. Aggravated by sour, salty, pungent.
- *Kapha* is calmed by **pungent, bitter, astringent** — light, dry, warm foods. Aggravated by sweet, sour, salty.

3. **A balanced meal includes all six.** This is the classical recommendation — a proper meal touches all six tastes, in proportions adjusted to the eater’s *prakṛti* and the season.
4. **A modern note.** Modern nutrition focuses on macronutrients (protein, fat, carbs) and micronutrients (vitamins, minerals). Ayurveda’s *six tastes* is a *qualitative* sorting that pre-dates that vocabulary. Both can be true at once: a balanced meal needs both macro coverage AND qualitative variety.

Activity (20 min) — Taste station rotation

Detailed protocol in [activities/activity-02-taste-station.md](#). Summary:

- Six small stations around the room. Each has the sample, a label, and a worksheet question.
- Students rotate in pairs. 2 minutes per station.

- At each station: taste a small sample. Write (a) the IAST + English name; (b) one descriptor word (cooling, warming, sharp, mild); (c) which *doṣa* you’d predict it calms.
- **Allergies / dietary restrictions:** opt-out at any station. No questions asked. Smell-only counts.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Whole-class share — “Which taste surprised you? Which felt familiar from your home cooking?”
- Preview Day 7: “Tomorrow — what does imbalance look like, and when do you stop using this framework and call a doctor?”

Student-facing content

The six tastes (*ṣaḍ-rasa*):

Taste	Example	Calms	Aggravates
<i>madhura</i> (sweet)	rice, milk, jaggery	vāta, pitta	kapha
<i>amla</i> (sour)	lemon, yoghurt	vāta	pitta, kapha
<i>lavaṇa</i> (salty)	rock salt	vāta	pitta, kapha
<i>kaṭu</i> (pungent)	chili, ginger	kapha	vāta, pitta
<i>tikta</i> (bitter)	methi, neem	pitta, kapha	vāta
<i>kaṣāya</i> (astringent)	unripe banana, black tea	pitta, kapha	vāta

A balanced meal touches all six. Indian thālīs often do this naturally (rice, dāl, vegetable, pickle, salad, raita, end-of-meal pān or yoghurt).

Homework

- At dinner tonight, count how many of the six tastes are on your plate. Note which are missing. (No need to “fix” anything — just observe.)

Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Pick a classic dish from any cuisine (your family’s, or anyone’s). Identify the six tastes in it. What balance is the recipe achieving?
- **One tier down:** Remember just three tastes — sweet, sour, salty (the *vāta*-calming three). They’re the ones in most home meals.

Teacher notes

- Reminder: NOT a diet plan. Don’t let students decide “I must eat bitter from now on.” It’s awareness.
- The *kaṭu* (pungent) station can be a strong sample — let students opt for sniffing only.
- Some students will discover they hate astringent or bitter. Note the cultural-conditioning point: most Indian cuisines train astringent (raw banana) and bitter (methi) deliberately, because they balance the heavy-sweet majority of the meal.
- Avoid talking about *doṣa*-specific diets in detail. This isn’t a meal-planning class.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- The *ṣaḍ-rasa* enumeration appears in Caraka Saṁhitā *Sūtrasthāna* 26 and Aṣṭāṅga Hṛdaya *Sūtrasthāna* 10. Concept only — no direct quote in lesson.